SEC WOMEN'S BASKETBALL TOURNAMENT · 2025–26 SEASON

2026 SEC Women's Basketball Tournament Preview

Greenville, SC · March 4–8, 2026 · Bon Secours Wellness Arena · Generated 2026-02-27

The Field at a Glance

TIER	SEED	TEAM	RECORD	CONF.	NET EFF.
CONTENDERS	1	**South Carolina**	28-2	14-1	+42.5
CONTENDERS	2	**Texas**	27-3	12-3	+40.6
CONTENDERS	3	**Vanderbilt**	26-3	12-3	+28.0
CONTENDERS	4	**LSU**	25-4	11-4	**+45.8**
CHALLENGERS	5	Oklahoma	22-6	10-5	+25.7
CHALLENGERS	6	Kentucky	21-8	8-7	+24.2
CHALLENGERS	7	Tennessee	16-11	8-7	+11.7
CHALLENGERS	8	Ole Miss	21-9	8-7	+21.1
BUBBLE	9	Alabama	21-8	7-8	+14.1
BUBBLE	10	Georgia	21-8	7-8	+18.0
BUBBLE	11	Texas A&M	13-11	6-9	−3.6
BUBBLE	12	Mississippi State	18-11	5-10	+12.5
BUBBLE	13	Florida	17-13	5-10	+10.3
LONGSHOTS	14	Missouri	16-14	4-11	−5.0
LONGSHOTS	15	Auburn	14-15	3-12	−3.5
LONGSHOTS	16	Arkansas	11-19	0-15	−7.6

LSU (seed 4) posts the highest Net Efficiency in the field at +45.8 — higher than #1 South Carolina (+42.5). This is the defining anomaly of the 2026 tournament.

Storylines to Watch

1. The LSU Seed Anomaly: The Best Team in the Field Is the Fourth Seed

By every efficiency metric — Net Efficiency (+45.8, best in field), ORtg (121.8, best in field), and SRS (46.93, second in field) — LSU is the best or second-best team in Greenville. They are seeded fourth because their conference record (11-4) trails the 12-3 marks of Texas and Vanderbilt. The catch: LSU's SOS of 11.11 is the second-lowest in the field. Two agents in this pipeline reach conflicting conclusions on the LSU-vs.-South Carolina semifinal. That disagreement is not reconciled here — it is the right question, and it will be answered on the court.

2. Tennessee's Ticking Clock: The Most Overseeded Team in the Field

Tennessee is a 7-seed with the statistical profile of an 11. Net Efficiency (+11.7) is the lowest of any team seeded 1–8. Their DRtg (89.8) is the worst among top-eight seeds. The defense: they played the hardest schedule in the entire field (SOS 19.77). But schedule credit evaporates at tipoff. Their three-point dependency (3PAr .457 — highest in the field) makes them one cold-shooting game away from elimination. Georgia in the Second Round will test them immediately.

3. Georgia's Quiet Case for a Semifinal Run

Georgia is a 10-seed that no one is talking about. Net Efficiency (+18.0) ranks eighth in the field — ahead of Tennessee, Alabama, and every other team seeded below them. DRtg (84.5) is the best of any team outside the top six seeds. The caveat: SOS (10.89) is second-lowest in the field. Both things are true simultaneously.

4. South Carolina vs. Texas: The Championship Game No One Should Argue With

South Carolina (ORtg 118.6, DRtg 76.1) and Texas (ORtg 116.3, DRtg 75.7) are statistically indistinguishable. The Net Efficiency gap is 1.9 points. Both teams lead the field in defensive efficiency and play interior-dominant basketball at identical paces. The Matchup Analyst gives South Carolina the edge solely on shooting efficiency (.587 vs. .559 TS%). Sub-Agent 2 calls it "a coin flip." This report agrees with both.

First Round · March 4

Seeds 1–8 have first-round byes. All games on SEC Network.

G1 · 11:00 AM EST · (9) ALABAMA VS. (16) ARKANSAS

Pick: Alabama **Confidence: High**

Arkansas went 0-15 in conference play. Net Efficiency gap: 21.7 points per 100 possessions. Alabama wins comfortably.

G2 · 1:30 PM EST · (12) MISSISSIPPI STATE VS. (13) FLORIDA

Pick: Mississippi State **Confidence: Low**

Tightest game of the first round. Net Efficiency gap: 2.2 points. Mississippi State's ORB% (37.7% vs. 34.9%) is the structural edge. Florida is a live underdog — treat with caution.

G3 · 6:00 PM EST · (10) GEORGIA VS. (15) AUBURN

Pick: Georgia **Confidence: High**

Auburn's ORtg (86.5) is the worst in the field. Georgia wins going away across every efficiency dimension.

G4 · 8:30 PM EST · (11) TEXAS A&M VS. (14) MISSOURI

Pick: Texas A&M **Confidence: Medium**

Missouri shoots far better (.557 TS%) but allows opponents to score at will (DRtg 103.7). Texas A&M's defensive edge wins. Caveat: Texas A&M played only 24 games — smallest sample in field.

Second Round · March 5

All games on SEC Network.

G5 · 11:00 AM EST · (8) OLE MISS VS. (9) ALABAMA

Pick: Ole Miss **Confidence: Medium-High**

Ole Miss leads in Net Efficiency (+7.0), DRtg (84.3 vs. 87.9), TOV% (16.0% vs. 18.4%), and ORB% (40.4% vs. 31.3%). Alabama's shooting edge keeps them live.

G6 · 1:30 PM EST · (5) OKLAHOMA VS. (12) MISSISSIPPI STATE

Pick: Oklahoma **Confidence: High**

Oklahoma's advantages are comprehensive. Net Efficiency gap: 13.2 points. Their pace (80.7 — fastest in field) forces a transition game Mississippi State cannot match.

G7 · 6:00 PM EST · (7) TENNESSEE VS. (10) GEORGIA

Pick: Georgia **Confidence: Medium**

Biggest seed-versus-metrics misalignment in the bracket. Georgia leads in Net Efficiency (+6.3), DRtg (84.5 vs. 89.8), and TS% (.538 vs. .507). Tennessee's SOS (19.77 vs. 10.89) is the legitimate counter — schedule credit that evaporates at tipoff.

G8 · 8:30 PM EST · (6) KENTUCKY VS. (11) TEXAS A&M

Pick: Kentucky **Confidence: High**

Kentucky's Net Efficiency advantage: 27.8 points — second-largest gap of any matchup in the bracket. Kentucky wins comfortably.

Quarterfinals · March 6

Seeds 1 and 2 enter here.

G9 · 12:00 PM EST · ESPN · (1) SOUTH CAROLINA VS. (8) OLE MISS

Pick: South Carolina **Confidence: High**

South Carolina's ORtg (118.6) is 13.2 points better per 100 possessions than Ole Miss's defense can contain. Net Efficiency advantage: 21.4 points.

G10 · 2:30 PM EST · ESPN · (4) LSU VS. (5) OKLAHOMA

Pick: LSU **Confidence: Medium**

LSU's ORB% (48.8%) is the defining number — when you recover half your own misses, your offense doesn't need to be perfect. Oklahoma's DRtg (81.4) and higher SOS are the counter. LSU's ceiling is simply too high to suppress.

G11 · 6:00 PM EST · SEC NETWORK · (2) TEXAS VS. (10) GEORGIA

Pick: Texas **Confidence: High**

Texas's DRtg (75.7 — best in field) holds Georgia well below their seasonal average. Texas's ORB% (41.0% vs. 30.6%) dominates the glass. Texas wins by double digits.

G12 · 8:30 PM EST · SEC NETWORK · (3) VANDERBILT VS. (6) KENTUCKY

Pick: Vanderbilt **Confidence: Medium**

Net Efficiency lead: 3.8 points. Vanderbilt's ORtg (115.6) beats Kentucky's (109.0) by 6.6 points — an offensive edge Kentucky's defense cannot fully absorb. Kentucky is the most likely quarterfinal upset.

Semifinals · March 7 · ESPN2

G13 · 4:30 PM EST · (1) SOUTH CAROLINA VS. (4) LSU

Pick: South Carolina **Confidence: Low**

The headline game of the tournament. LSU has the best raw profile in Greenville by Net Efficiency (+45.8), ORtg (121.8), and ORB% (48.8%). South Carolina's SOS-adjusted advantage (16.66 vs. 11.11) is the only structural counter. Sub-Agent 3 picks South Carolina. Sub-Agent 4 calls it "essentially a coin flip" and refuses to resolve the disagreement. This report picks South Carolina — while acknowledging LSU wins this often enough to make the pick feel arbitrary. LSU's ORB% (48.8% vs. 40.4%) is the X-factor.

G14 · 7:00 PM EST · (2) TEXAS VS. (3) VANDERBILT

Pick: Texas **Confidence: High**

Texas's DRtg (75.7) is 11.9 points better than Vanderbilt's — the largest defensive advantage in any semifinal. Vanderbilt's offense (ORtg 115.6) is exceptional but cannot sustain itself against the best defense in the field. Texas wins by 8–12.

Championship · March 8 · ESPN · 3:00 PM EDT

G15 · (1) SOUTH CAROLINA VS. (2) TEXAS

Pick: **South Carolina wins the 2026 SEC Tournament — 62-58** Confidence: Low

The numbers side by side:

ORtg: South Carolina 118.6 · Texas 116.3 (SC +2.3)
DRtg: Texas 75.7 · South Carolina 76.1 (Texas +0.4)
Net Efficiency: South Carolina +42.5 · Texas +40.6 (SC +1.9)
TS%: South Carolina 58.7% · Texas 55.9% (SC +2.8 pts)
SOS: 16.66 · 16.39 · Pace: 73.9 · 73.7

Every number points to the same conclusion: these teams are functionally equal. The tiebreaker is South Carolina's shooting efficiency (.587 TS% — largest individual edge between them). Confidence is Low. This is not a failure of analysis. It is the correct result when two equally elite programs meet in single elimination. Texas is fully capable of winning this championship.

Bracket Picks Summary

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FIRST ROUND (Mar 4)         SECOND ROUND (Mar 5)       QUARTERFINALS (Mar 6)
_______________________     _______________________    _______________________

(9)  Alabama     ──┐
                   ├─ Alabama ──┐
(16) Arkansas    ──┘            │
                                ├─ Ole Miss ───┐
(8)  Ole Miss ─────────────────┘               │
                                               ├─ South Carolina
(12) Miss. State ──┐                           │
                   ├─ Miss. State ──┐          │
(13) Florida     ──┘               │          │
                                   ├─ Oklahoma ─┘
(5)  Oklahoma ─────────────────────┘
_______________________
(10) Georgia     ──┐
                   ├─ Georgia ──┐
(15) Auburn      ──┘            │
                                ├─ Georgia ───┐
(7)  Tennessee ────────────────┘              │
                                              ├─ Texas
(11) Texas A&M   ──┐                          │
                   ├─ Texas A&M ──┐           │
(14) Missouri    ──┘              │           │
                                  ├─ Kentucky ─┘
(6)  Kentucky ────────────────────┘

_____________________________________________________________________
SEMIFINALS (Mar 7)            CHAMPIONSHIP (Mar 8)
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────────────────────────     ──────────────────────────
South Carolina ──┐
                 ├─ South Carolina ──┐
LSU ─────────────┘                   │
                                     ├── SOUTH CAROLINA ◀ CHAMPION
Texas ───────────┐                   │
                 ├─ Texas ───────────┘
Vanderbilt ──────┘
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ROUND	MATCHUP	PICK	CONFIDENCE
First Round	(9) Alabama vs. (16) Arkansas	**Alabama**	**High**
First Round	(12) Mississippi State vs. (13) Florida	**Mississippi State**	**Low**
First Round	(10) Georgia vs. (15) Auburn	**Georgia**	**High**
First Round	(11) Texas A&M vs. (14) Missouri	**Texas A&M**	**Medium**
Second Round	(8) Ole Miss vs. (9) Alabama	**Ole Miss**	**Medium-High**
Second Round	(5) Oklahoma vs. (12) Mississippi State	**Oklahoma**	**High**
Second Round	(7) Tennessee vs. (10) Georgia	**Georgia** ⚡	**Medium**
Second Round	(6) Kentucky vs. (11) Texas A&M	**Kentucky**	**High**
Quarterfinals	(1) South Carolina vs. (8) Ole Miss	**South Carolina**	**High**
Quarterfinals	(4) LSU vs. (5) Oklahoma	**LSU**	**Medium**
Quarterfinals	(2) Texas vs. (10) Georgia	**Texas**	**High**
Quarterfinals	(3) Vanderbilt vs. (6) Kentucky	**Vanderbilt**	**Medium**
Semifinals	(1) South Carolina vs. (4) LSU	**South Carolina**	**Low**
Semifinals	(2) Texas vs. (3) Vanderbilt	**Texas**	**High**
Championship	(1) South Carolina vs. (2) Texas	**South Carolina** 🏆	**Low**

Projected Final Four: South Carolina · LSU · Texas · Vanderbilt

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Upset Alert

UPSET PICK NO. 1 · SUB-AGENT 4 RATING: HIGH

Georgia (10) over Tennessee (7) — Second Round

Georgia's Net Efficiency (+18.0) beats Tennessee's (+11.7) by 6.3 points. DRtg advantage: 5.3 points (84.5 vs. 89.8). Tennessee is a 7-seed with an 11th-ranked efficiency profile. The bracket calls this an upset. The numbers have called Georgia the better team all season.

UPSET PICK NO. 2 · STRUCTURAL BRACKET BUSTER

LSU (4) Runs to the Championship

Net Efficiency +45.8 (best in field). ORtg 121.8 (best in field). ORB% 48.8% (best in field by a wide margin). LSU is the 4-seed. LSU has the best efficiency profile. Both true. Their offensive rebounding is a structural weapon no team in this field has an answer for.

UPSET PICK NO. 3 · SUB-AGENT 4 RATING: MEDIUM

Mississippi State (12) over Oklahoma (5) — Second Round

Style mismatch: Mississippi State is a slow half-court team (73.4 pace). Oklahoma wants to run (80.7 — fastest in field). In single elimination, a disciplined slower team can drag a faster team into a grind. MSU's ORB% (37.7%) provides the mechanism.

Statistical Leaders

Offensive Efficiency (ORtg)

RANK	TEAM	SEED	ORTG
1	**LSU**	**4**	**121.8**
2	South Carolina	1	118.6
3	Texas	2	116.3
4	Vanderbilt	3	115.6
5	Kentucky	6	109.0

Defensive Efficiency (DRtg — lower is better)

RANK	TEAM	SEED	DRTG
1	**Texas**	**2**	**75.7**
2	LSU	4	76.0
3	South Carolina	1	76.1
4	Oklahoma	5	81.4
5	Ole Miss	8	84.3

Net Efficiency (ORtg – DRtg)

RANK	TEAM	SEED	NET
1	**LSU**	**4**	**+45.8**
2	South Carolina	1	+42.5
3	Texas	2	+40.6
4	Vanderbilt	3	+28.0
5	Oklahoma	5	+25.7

Data Note: All statistics from `data/sec_teams.csv`, generated by scraping Sports Reference's 2025-26 Women's Advanced School Stats and Advanced Opponent Stats pages (scraped 2026-02-27). DRtg derived from opponent ORtg allowed. Tournament seedings from `data/bracket.json`, derived from conference win percentage with SRS as tiebreaker. Texas A&M's 24-game sample (vs. 27–30 for all other teams) flagged as a minor uncertainty. Where Sub-Agents 3 and 4 disagreed, both views are preserved rather than resolved.